



“ THE NEOLITHIC WAS... A POINT IN A CONTINUOUS STORY OF GREATER ECONOMIC CONTROL OVER RESOURCES... FROM SCAVENGING TO... FARMING. ”

Clive Gamble, from *Origins and revolutions: human identity in earliest prehistory*, 2007

by Old and New World farmers. By 5000 BCE cattle, sheep, and goats were **raised for milk** as well as meat, while cattle were used to pull **plows**, enabling people to cultivate much larger areas.

Wool-bearing sheep were bred in West Asia in the 4th millennium BCE, and rapidly spread into Europe and Central Asia. The use of **pack animals** such as llamas and donkeys allowed long-distance transport.

Agriculture was more productive than foraging and could support **larger communities**. Settled life also encouraged **population growth**. Many early farming villages in West Asia grew to a considerable size. Most remarkable was **Çatalhöyük** in Turkey, occupied around 7400–6200 BCE, which housed as many as 8,000 people. Its tightly packed houses were entered from the roof by ladders, and were decorated with paintings and

modeled animal heads.

After 7000 BCE **farmers spread** from Turkey into southeast and central Europe, while Mediterranean hunter-gatherers gradually turned to agriculture, using imported West Asian crops and animals. By 3500 BCE most of Europe had adopted farming.

Megaliths—stone chambered tombs of which a wide variety were built, often with earthen mounds—were constructed in western and northern Europe from the early 5th millennium BCE. Most housed the bones of a number of individuals.

Native (naturally occurring pure) **copper and gold** were being shaped into small objects by cold hammering before 8000 BCE in West Asia. Around 7000 BCE, **ores were smelted** here to extract metal and by 6000 BCE copper and lead were also cast. Metals were initially made into small personal objects that could enhance prestige and status. Later, however, copper began to be used for **tools**, and by 4200 BCE copper ores containing arsenic were deliberately selected to produce a harder metal. The addition of tin created a stronger alloy, **bronze**, which was in use in West Asia by 3200 BCE.

The development of **water-control techniques** enabled West Asian farmers to colonize the southern **Mesopotamian plains**, where agriculture depended entirely on irrigation but was highly productive. By the mid 4th millennium BCE, this region was densely populated, and villages were developing into **towns**, with craft specialists. There was a growing demand for raw materials, including metal ores, which often came from distant sources. A **trading**

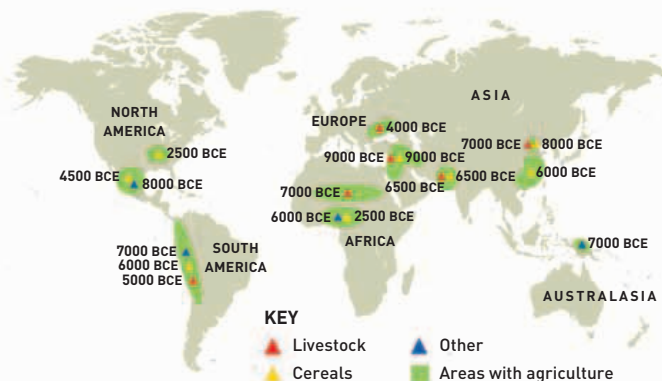
CHINCHORRO MUMMIES

The earliest mummies come not from Egypt, but from coastal northern Chile, an arid region where natural mummies occur from 7000 BCE. After 5000 BCE the Chinchorro began artificial mummification. They removed the flesh, reassembled and reinforced the skeleton, stuffed the skin with plant material, coated it in clay, and painted it with black manganese or red ochre. Only some individuals, particularly children, were mummified.



network developed that stretched from Egypt through West Asia to the mountainous borderlands of South Asia, with towns controlling sources of materials and strategic points along the routes. **Sumer** (southern Mesopotamia) was at the forefront of this development, but social, religious, economic, and political complexity was also

emerging in **Elam** (southwest Iran) and **Egypt**. Before 3000 BCE all three regions developed **writing systems**, used to record and manage economic transactions and the ownership of property. The earliest known pictographic writing, around 3300 BCE, comes from **Uruk** in Sumer, a huge and complex settlement that is deservedly known as the **world's first city**.



The spread of agriculture

Humans began to cultivate plants and manage animals independently, in different areas at different times, across the world.

Copper ax heads

Gold and copper were the first metals to be worked. They became widespread in Europe around 2500 BCE.

